

Room 313

Dr. Mira Elwood thought she'd seen it all when it came to messed-up memories. She helped folks who'd forgotten who they were, people stuck in time warps, and even a guy who swore his childhood dog (that no one else remembered) was haunting him.

She was pretty sure nothing could shock her anymore.

Then the letter showed up.

No stamp, no return address—just a sentence typed in Courier font:

`"There's a room that remembers everything. You should see it."`

It came with a key and a train ticket to a town she'd never even heard of which wasn't even on the map.

She should've tossed it, burned it, and moved on. But she packed her bag instead.

The train ride was super weird. It took forever. The scenery kept changing: forests, deserts, oceans, skies packed with black birds.

She straight up just lost track of time.

When the train finally stopped, she saw the station name carved into the wall: Eidolon.

She got off. Nobody else did. Actually, nobody else was even around.

The streets were silent. Buildings looked empty. Everything was still. But a taxi was waiting.

The driver's face was just smooth skin.

He just said, "Room 313," ... and drove off.

The taxi dropped her at a huge hotel—black stone, dark glass, all these sharp angles that made it look like it was watching her.

The lobby was huge and freezing. A woman sat at the desk, eyes wide, lips sewn shut.

Without a word, she slid a key across the counter. The same key. Room 313.

The woman whispered (somehow) in a voice like wind: No elevator. Stairs.

Mira started climbing. Floor after floor.

Each floor's doors had strange numbers. Some numbers showed up twice. Some went backward.

On the 312th floor, she stopped. There was a mirror on the wall. She looked and almost freaked out.

Her reflection wasn't her, or it was, but older: skinny, tired, with gray hair. Then it smiled.

She ran. She didn't stop running until she got to Room 313.

The key clicked in the lock. She opened the door. And there it was.

A chair. A bright light. Bookshelves full of really old books lined every wall.

Each book had a name, a date, and a lock.

A note sat in the middle of the room: This room remembers everything. Every life, lie, sin, secret, truth you've forgotten. Sit. Read. Remember what you chose to forget.

No way. She should've walked away.

But she sat down.

She grabbed a book, touching its spine. Her name was on it: Mira Elwood.

She opened it. Page one said: Mira Elwood was born in Boston, Massachusetts, on March 14, 1983. She never had a brother, lost a child, committed a crime. She is a good person.

Liar!

She flipped through the pages. Suddenly, pictures popped up from the ink.

She saw herself holding a baby. She saw herself by a hospital bed, her eyes were dark. She saw herself driving in the rain. She saw herself striking a match. She saw flames. She heard screams. And she saw herself walking away.

Stuff she couldn't remember. Stuff she'd blocked out.

The book whispered: You wanted to forget. But I remember.

That night, she heard a voice behind the wall. Small. Familiar.

Mommy?

Her heart stopped. It had been fifteen years since she heard that voice!

Not since the incident. Not since the fire. Not since she erased it all.

The next morning, the room was different. More chairs, shelves, and mirrors.

A kid's drawing hung on the wall. It showed a family: Mommy, Daddy, Baby.

Except, Mira never had a husband or a baby... Or did she?

She touched the drawing. It turned to ash.

Days went by. She didn't sleep, eat, or leave. The room was getting to her, digging up every memory.

She remembered the boy. Jacob. Her son.

He'd died in the fire. Not an incident, a choice. Her choice.

She lit the match. The pain was too bad. She thought it would ease the suffering. She messed up big time.

On the thirtieth night, Mira stood at the stairwell. She knew what was upstairs and in Room 314. She went on the stairs.

Past doors that whispered her name. Past mirrors that showed her younger, happier faces.

She opened the door.

The room inside was even more silent. A chair, a light, a book.

Hers, already open. The last page was blank. A pen waited.

She wrote: Mira Elwood was born in Boston, Massachusetts, on March 14, 1983. She had a son named Jacob. He died in a fire. She lit the match. She never forgave herself. She will never leave this place.

The lights flickered. Everything changed.

Mirrors were all over the walls. Books snapped shut. Doors locked.

Then, in the corner, she saw him! A little boy. Smiling.

He had her eyes.

Hi, Mommy.

Footsteps grew closer in the hall. More visitors, guests, sins, and stories.

The room would never stop remembering. Never stop taking from her sanity.

Mira realized it too late. She wasn't a guest; she was part of the room.

A keeper of memories, a witness to truth, a prisoner of guilt forever.

Outside, a young man held a key. He looked at the hotel's sign.

Room 313.

He stepped inside. The door closed.

Room 313 waited. Waiting for its next occupant and sins.